Project 3: Creative Campaign and Æffect Report

Ready from Bell to Bell

Cause: reliable access to free menstrual supplies in North Carolina public schools · Campaign focus: Watauga County Schools · Campaign period: three weeks, October–November · Report: 1,398 words

> **A note on this model.** This is the example Project 3 for ENG 4100, written as a finished student paper so you can see the shape of one. It continues the campaign from the example Project 2, so the frame, the characters, and the ask are the same ones diagnosed and built there. The numbers reported in the evaluation section are illustrative of what a completed campaign's results look like at this scale. Your own report uses your own counts, whatever they turn out to be.

Part One: The Campaign

The narrative I am carrying in from Project 2

The frame I built in Project 2 refuses the personal-preparedness story. The inherited story asks whether a student should have brought supplies and whether the school ought to help her out. My frame moves the question onto the institution: a school that is ready for students has what students need to stay in class. The campaign's line is *Pencils. Soap. Pads. A school day should be ready for all three.* The protagonist is a student trying to finish a science lab rather than a student waiting to be rescued, and the school is a capable institution with a practical decision in front of it.

George Lakoff's argument in *Don't Think of an Elephant!* (2004) is why the campaign never argues with the preparedness story directly. Saying "students should not be blamed for forgetting" keeps forgetting at the center of the sentence. So every artifact below is built to make a claim rather than to rebut one, and the strongest of them makes it without a sentence at all.

Artifact 1: the Ready Shelf (the artifact that cannot be distributed on social media)

A free-standing shelf, 36 inches tall and 20 inches wide, built from plywood offcuts in the campus Maker Space and hand-painted. It holds three open bins, labeled in hand-lettered paint: PENCILS, SOAP, PADS. All three are free to take. It stood in the ground-floor atrium of the student union for three weeks, restocked by me every other day.

The shelf is the argument. Nobody who walks past it has to be told that a school stocks pencils and soap as a matter of course, so putting pads in the third bin, at the same height, in the same

handwriting, makes the claim by arrangement rather than by assertion. The design borrows its mechanism from the AIDS Memorial Quilt, where meaning comes from assembly: one bin alone is a supply closet, and three bins together are a position.

What presence adds that a post could not. A photograph of the shelf is an image of an argument. The shelf is an encounter with it, and the encounter is private in a way a feed cannot reproduce. A student who needs a pad can take one without asking an adult, without an application, and without anybody knowing she needed it, which is the exact condition the campaign says a school day should already provide. The artifact therefore does the thing it advocates while it advocates for it. It also cannot be scrolled past. A person in that atrium either walks around it or stops at it, and over three weeks roughly 190 supplies left the third bin, each one a transaction that only happened because somebody was standing there.

Artifact 2: 200 hand-stamped Ready cards

Four-by-six cards on cream stock, each carrying a hand-carved rubber stamp of the campaign mark pressed hard enough to emboss the paper, so the mark can be felt as well as seen. On the back, one line to finish in the writer's own pen: *A school day should be ready for* _____. Blank cards and a pen sat on the shelf's top surface; filled cards went into a slot cut in the side.

The cards are deliberately a two-minute action. Marshall Ganz's public-narrative structure sits behind them: the card asks a person for the smallest possible version of a Story of Self, one line, no name attached, and the stack turns those into a Story of Us that nobody could have written alone.

Artifact 3: the carry

At the end of three weeks, the returned cards were banded into a single stack and carried by hand into the Watauga County Board of Education's public-comment period. Three of us spoke for three minutes total, holding the stack up while we did. The stack was then left with the board clerk along with a one-page summary.

This artifact is the only one that could not exist in any other medium, because its content is its weight. A board member can disregard an email and can disregard a petition link. The physical presence of 164 cards, each in different handwriting, standing in the room, is an argument about how many people are in the room.

Artifact 4: the zine

A one-page zine, folded into eight panels, printed 140 times and stacked on the shelf. Panel one is the campaign line. Panels two and three explain North Carolina's 2026 distribution law in plain language. Panels four through six give the three asks for the district: confirm participation, say where supplies are, and publish a restocking plan. Panel seven is the ask with the board meeting date; panel eight is blank on purpose, so it can be written on.

The social channels, defended rather than defaulted to

The campaign used one Instagram post and one Facebook post, and used them for logistics only: where the shelf is, and when the board meets. That restriction is a design decision, and the reasoning comes from Jodi Dean. Dean's account of communicative capitalism describes a condition where circulation substitutes for politics: a message can travel very far while nothing is asked of anybody and no official ever has to answer. A campaign about an object in a room is unusually easy to convert into exactly that kind of circulation, because the shelf photographs well. So the posts carry an address and a time rather than a feeling, and the decision is deliberate: the posts exist to put people in front of the artifact instead of in front of an image of it.

Part Two: The *Æffect* Report

1. Goals

Three, each one either happening or not. Get at least three people to speak during the board's public-comment period. Get a written response from the district confirming whether it is participating in the state distribution program and how supplies are restocked. Get 120 of the 200 cards returned with writing on them.

2. Audience

Primary: the five members of the Watauga County Board of Education and the district's assistant superintendent, who is the person who would actually write a restocking plan. Secondary: the students and staff who pass through the atrium, most of whom did not know the state program existed. Reached through: the shelf itself, two student organizations whose officers agreed to pass the zine along, and one middle-school teacher who keeps a supply drawer in her classroom and was willing to say so.

3. Ethics

No student was photographed. No minors were interviewed. The cards stayed unsigned, and the stack was photographed as a stack so that no individual handwriting became public. The sign on the shelf said outright where the cards would be taken and when. Before any of it was built, I contacted the district to ask what already existed, because a campaign that manufactures a failure in order to solve it is a campaign about itself; if the supplies had turned out to be reliably stocked, the plan was to document that and say so. The district was never drawn as an opponent. The decision we discussed and refused was putting a photograph of an empty dispenser on the zine, because we could not establish that the dispenser we found empty was representative, and an image that argues more than the evidence supports is a lie with a caption.

4. Intervention

The four artifacts above, run for three weeks in the atrium, closing with the carry into the November board meeting. A baseline was built into the shelf on the first two days: two jars and a bowl of dried beans, with the question "Did you know North Carolina has a program that supplies schools with these?" Beans in the yes jar or the no jar, counted at the end of each day.

5. Metrics, set before the campaign ran

What	How it was counted	Set in advance
Cards returned	200 out, counted back in	Target 120. Under 60 would mean the prompt failed.
Card language	Each card coded once: charity language, readiness language, or neither	Readiness language on a majority of cards
Supplies taken	Restock count from the third bin	No target. This is demand, and the point was to learn it.
Speakers at public comment	Head count in the room	Three
District response	A written reply, dated	Yes or no
Baseline awareness	Beans in two jars, two days	No target. A before figure.
Affect	Every line said at the shelf, written down with the time, used only with permission	No target. Quoted, not counted.

6. Evaluation

164 of 200 cards came back with writing on them, which clears the target of 120. Thirty-six are unaccounted for and I do not know where they went. Of the 164, 96 used readiness language of some kind, usually by comparison: "like soap," "the way there's always toilet paper," "it should already be there." Eleven used charity language, mostly the verb "donate." The remaining 57 did neither, and most of those were about something else entirely, which is its own finding about what a blank line invites.

The baseline jars came in at 38 yes and 121 no, so roughly three out of four people who stopped did not know the state program existed. That number did more to justify the campaign than anything I had argued in Project 2.

About 190 supplies left the third bin over three weeks, and the bin was empty within four days of the first stocking. 140 zines went. Three of us spoke at the November meeting, which met the target exactly. The assistant superintendent replied in writing twelve days later confirming that the district had elected to participate in the state program, and the district posted a page describing where supplies are kept and who restocks them.

Two things did not work, and the first one was my fault. On day nine, building staff moved the shelf about forty feet into a corner because it was narrowing a walkway, and foot traffic past it dropped by roughly half for the remaining twelve days. I had verbal permission for the installation and nothing in writing, and no measurement of the walkway. The second failure is the Spanish-language cards. Forty of the 200 were printed in Spanish, and four came back. I do not read Spanish, the translation was not checked by anybody who does, and I have no way of knowing whether the prompt even made sense. That is a design failure that selected against part of the audience I said I wanted.

Affect, which the counts missed almost entirely. Three lines were written down at the shelf on the day they were said and are used here with permission. "I didn't know you were allowed to just take one" (October 28, 11:15 a.m.). "My mom used to put them in a Ziploc in my backpack and I was so embarrassed" (October 30, 2:40 p.m.). "Is this allowed?", asked twice on the first morning by two different people, which I did not expect and which is the single most useful thing the campaign taught me. What no metric caught: two people stood and read the card wall for several minutes and then left without writing anything or taking a supply, and I have no idea what that was.

7. Iteration

Get the location in writing from the building manager and measure the walkway before building, and build the next shelf at 14 inches deep rather than 20. Get the Spanish version written or checked by a person who speaks Spanish, and if that cannot be arranged, do not print it and say why in the report. Put the ask on the card itself, since a person holding a pen is the most willing they will be all day. And keep the jars: a two-day baseline cost nothing and produced the campaign's most useful number.

Access

Digital accessibility applied to the two posts (alt text on both, readable type on the graphic, no text over a busy photograph). For the analog work, six of the seven analog access moves were designed in from the start, and one was not solved.

- **Physical access.** The atrium is step-free from two entrances. The shelf's top surface, where the cards and pen sat, was set at 30 inches so somebody seated could reach it, and the pads bin was the middle bin rather than the top one for the same reason.
- **Print and sight.** All printed text at 14pt or larger, black on cream, nothing set over an image. Twenty of the 200 cards were printed at 18pt, and twenty zines were printed one-sided at 18pt.
- **Time, seating, and stamina.** The card is a two-minute action, and taking a supply is a ten-second one. Two chairs were placed beside the shelf. Nothing required standing in a line.
- **Sensory load.** No sound element, no amplification, nothing that moved or flashed. The shelf was a quiet object in a loud building on purpose.
- **Touch and non-visual access.** The campaign mark was carved and pressed deep enough to emboss, so the mark is feelable, and the three bins were labeled with raised paint. On the two days I was tabling, I offered to read the prompt aloud and write the answer down for anybody who wanted that.
- **A route in for people who could not be there.** A drop box at the union's front desk and a mailing address printed on the back of every card. Nine cards came in that way, and I carried those nine into the meeting myself.
- **Language: not solved.** See the evaluation section. This is the one I would fix first.

Documentation

Submitted with this report: eleven photographs (the shelf as built, the shelf in both locations, the three bins, the card slot, the stack banded for the carry, the board clerk's receipt); the shelf itself, which can be brought to class; one unused card and one returned card, with permission; one zine; and a spreadsheet of the card coding with 164 rows.

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